

The Person Case Constraint (PCC) and the constraints on honorific markers

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ABSTRACT

The realization of honorific markers is driven by $\phi(\varphi)$ -feature agreement, specifically through first and second person features, rather than a dedicated honorific feature (see Wang 2023). In detail, I show that restrictions on honorification align with a version of the Person Case Constraint (PCC). This approach unifies two seemingly unrelated phenomena at first approximation, namely honorification and the PCC (see Adamson & Zompì 2024 for politeness pronouns and the PCC). The analysis accounts for why only certain arguments can bear honorific morphology, depending on their structural position. By recasting honorification as a case of person feature agreement, the proposal secures parsimony that links honorification to a broader theoretical constraint, while lending credence to the idea that syntax encodes pragmatic information through core grammatical features (see Pancheva & Zubizarreta 2018). To this end, two independent-looking phenomena receive a parallel treatment in syntax. I provide implications about argument structure and cross-linguistic evidence supporting the overarching claim of the paper.

Keywords: Person Case Constraint (PCC), honorific markers, argument structure, intervention

1 Introduction

The Person Case Constraint (PCC) is a restriction observed in many languages that use clitic pronouns or agreement morphology to mark indirect objects (IO) and direct objects (DO). The constraint blocks certain combinations of person features, typically when the IO is higher on the person hierarchy than the DO. A version of the Person Case Constraint (PCC) states that the DO clitic cannot be first person or second person (1/2P) when the IO clitic is 1/2P.

- (1) IO_{1/2P} ... DO_{*1/*2P} (1/2P > 3P)

The PCC is observed in various languages, including Catalan, French, Greek, and Spanish. (2) provides evidence of the PCC effect in Greek.¹

- (2) a. Tha **mu** **to** stilune.
FUT 1.GEN 3.N.ACC send.3PL
'They will send it to me'

¹The glossing in this paper follows the Leipzig glossing conventions, with additional abbreviations: 1 = first person; 2 = second person; 3 = third person; ACC = accusative; CAUS = causative; DAT = dative; D = declarative; FUT = future; GEN = genitive; H = honorific; H.DAT = honorific dative; H.NOM = honorific nominative; NOM = nominative; PASS = passive; plural = PL; PST = past; SG = singular.

- b. *Tha **mu** **se** sistisune.
 FUT 1.GEN 2.ACC introduce.3PL
 ‘They will introduce you to me.’ (Greek, Anagnostopoulou 2005:202)

Although the PCC has traditionally been analyzed as a constraint on the interaction between person and case features, I will show that a comparable restriction arises in languages that exhibit honorific markers.

- (3) IO_H ... DO_{*H} (H > non-H)

Empirical evidence mainly comes from Korean. (4), for instance, shows that the DO cannot receive an honorific accusative case marker (H.ACC) while the IO can receive an honorific dative case marker (H.ACC).

- (4) Mina-ka halme.nim-**kkey** sensayng.nim-**ul** sokayhay-ss-e-yo.
 Mina-NOM grandma.H-H.DAT teacher.H-(*H.)ACC introduce-PST-D-YO
 ‘Mina introduced the teacher to grandmother.’ (1P: Ann, 2P: Ann’s mom)

According to Adger & Harbour (2007) and Pancheva & Zubizarreta (2018), IOs are introduced by the Applicative (Appl) head, which is responsible for checking 1st and 2nd person features on the IO. Pancheva & Zubizarreta argue that Appl serves as the syntactic locus of perspective, encoding the information about the speaker (1P) and the addressee (2P). Because 1/2P licensing is structurally linked to IOs via Appl, direct objects (DOs) cannot bear these features, giving rise to the Person Case Constraint (PCC) effect illustrated in (1). Building on this analysis, I suggest that a similar mechanism underlies the distribution of honorific (H) case markers in Korean: only IOs can receive H case marking, whereas DOs cannot — even when both internal arguments (IAs) are nominal-internally marked for honorification, as shown in (4).

Under the current analysis, honorific (H) agreement is epiphenomenal, and honorification is person feature agreement in disguise. Parsimony is maintained in the sense that an honorific feature need not be posited in the grammar (see also Wang 2023). The facts follow from what I already understand as $\phi(\varphi)$ -features.

This work is organized as follows: Section 2 discusses a version of the PCC that is relevant to our phenomena of interest. Section 3 draws parallels between the PCC effect and the restrictions on Korean H case markers. The section also introduces a φ -feature agreement-based approach to handling honorification. Section 4 presents cross-linguistic evidence, which speaks in favor of the current proposal. Section 5 concludes.

2 The PCC effect

The Person Case Constraint (PCC) is a syntactic phenomenon observed in certain languages where constraints are imposed on the co-occurrence of clitic pronouns with respect to their person features. Specifically, the PCC restricts the combination of clitic pronouns based on their person hierarchy. Generally, it states that the DO clitic cannot be 1/2P if the IO clitic is present. Several versions of the PCC have been put forward in the literature. The following version is taken from Adger & Harbour (2007):

- (5) The Person Case Constraint (Adger & Harbour 2007:4)
 In a ditransitive, where both internal arguments are realized as phonologically weak elements, the direct object must be third person.

This effect is prevalent in many Romance languages, impacting grammaticality.

- (6) a. On **me** **le** montrera.
 one me.DAT it.ACC show.FUT
 ‘They will show it to me.’
 b. *On **me** **lui** montrera.
 one me.ACC him.DAT show.FUT
 ‘They will show me to him.’ (French, Adger & Harbour 2007:3)

Case plays an important role. Contrast (6b) with (7), for instance. The IO in (6b) is associated with DAT whereas the IO in (7) is associated with *à* ‘to,’ which constitutes a PP. This difference between the two is enough to capture the change in grammaticality.

- (7) On **me** montrera **à lui**.
 one me.ACC show.FUT to him
 ‘They will show me to him.’ (French, Adger & Harbour 2007:3)

(6) and (7) show that the PCC effect is regulated by person and case features. The effect is a matter of how the two grammatical properties interact, as the two can be closely intertwined with each other.

The PCC has been a subject of extensive theoretical investigation due to its implications on our understanding of argument structure and the intricate interplay between syntax and morphology. One line of research suggests that the PCC reflects the need for certain syntactic features to be checked in a local fashion. While the PCC is prominently observed in Romance languages, similar constraints appear in other language families, though the specific rules and manifestations can vary. This work makes a contribution in this respect. I propose that the restrictions observed for honorification in Korean and Japanese can be captured using the basic mechanisms introduced to account for the PCC. Making use of person features, I wish to bring the two phenomena closer together and ensure parsimony when handling their restrictions in syntax.

3 Honorification

The distribution of the H case markers in Korean showcases a restriction akin to the PCC effect discussed in Section 2. Table 1 provides a list of case makers in Korean. A subject can be associated with H.NOM, and an applied argument (e.g., an IO) can be associated with H.DAT. Quite crucially, there is no reserved morphology for H.ACC. Hence, a DO cannot be associated with H.ACC. In fact, a DO cannot be associated with any of the H case markers in the Korean case paradigm. Although a DO can be realized with plain NOM in psych verb constructions, H.NOM cannot replace NOM in this context (see Lee 2023, 2024). I will return to this issue later in this section.

Gloss	Phonological content
NOM	-i~-ka
H.NOM	-kkeyse
DAT	-eykey
H.DAT	-kkey
ACC	-(l)ul
H.ACC	N/A

Table 1: Korean case markers

In the domain of honorificity, the PCC effect takes a slightly different form. The issue is not strictly tied to the person features of IAs per se. Instead, the issue is about whether the speaker and the addressee information (i.e., 1/2P) are available in the featural make-up of these IAs (see Stegovec 2020). After all, determining the level of honorificity requires reference to both the speaker (1P) and the addressee (2P). This is evidenced by the fact that honorification can be suppressed by the social status of the addressee in relation to those of the speaker and the referent (e.g., the IO). In (8), let us assume that the IO, Ann’s grandmother, is equal in social status to the addressee, Ann’s grandfather. In this context, the speaker, Ann, uses plain DAT instead of H.DAT when expressing the referent IO, *halmeni* ‘grandmother.’ The contrast between (4) and (8) suggests that both 1P and 2P are necessary when honorification is at play.

- (8) Mina-ka halmeni-**eykey** sensayng.nim-ul sokayhay-ss-e-yo.
Mina-NOM grandma-DAT teacher.H-ACC introduce-PST-D-YO
‘Mina introduced the teacher to grandma.’ (1P: Ann, 2P: Ann’s grandpa)

(9) shows how H case markers employ person features. In (9), the IO receives 1/2P while the DO does not. Attentive readers may have already noticed that the information about the referent (e.g., R_1 or R_2) comes for free since the referent is the nominal argument itself (e.g., the IO or the DO). I assume that 1/2P *feed* the realization of honorific (H) case markers. I also assume that the feature bundle [1/2P, R(EFERENT)] contains all of the information necessary for honorification. In contrast, a bundle like [$\emptyset$, R(EFERENT)] lacks the features 1/2P. Hence, it fails to license honorification.

- (9) a. $IO_{[1/2P, R_1]} \rightarrow IO-(H.)DAT$ (H is possible)
b. $DO_{[2P, R_2]} \rightarrow DO-(^*H.)ACC$ (H is not possible)

Adger & Harbour suggest that person feature agreement and argument introduction are fundamentally linked. This aligns with Pancheva & Zubizarreta in that the licensing of 1/2P is carried out between Appl and its applied argument. Adopting this view, I argue that 1/2P on Appl is licensed only to the argument introduced by Appl. A question arises as to whether a DO can receive H case marker. The answer is no, as demonstrated in (10). Note that (10) is a psych verb construction which contains a NOM-marked DO. Crucially, NOM on the DO cannot be replaced with H.NOM, even though the DO is an honorifiable referent, namely *halapenim* ‘grandfather.’ This is because a DO can never be an applied argument introduced by Appl. Hence, there is no functional head that can supply 1/2P to the DO.

- (10) Mina-eykey halape.nim{-i/***kkeyse**} kuliw-e.
 Mina-DAT grandfather-NOM/*H.NOM miss-D
 ‘Mina misses grandpa.’ (psych verb)

The absence of H.ACC in Korean naturally follows from the foregoing discussion. To reiterate, there is no head that can supply 1/2P to the DO. (11) is a case in point.

- (11) Mina-ka halape.nim-**lul** an-ass-e.
 Mina-NOM grandpa.H-(*H.)ACC hug-PST-D
 ‘Mina hugged grandpa.’ (simple transitive)

The current analysis also makes the prediction that applied arguments other than IOs, such as beneficiaries and causees, should also be eligible for H case assignment. This prediction is borne out as shown in (12).

- (12) a. Mina-ka halme.nim-**kkey** khayikh-ul kwuwe-tuli-ess-e.
 Mina-NOM grandma.H-H.DAT cake-ACC bake-give.H-PST-D
 ‘Mina baked a cake for grandma.’ (benefactive)
 b. Kamtoknim-kkeyse paywunim-**kkey** chima-lul ip-hi-si-ess-e.
 director-H.NOM actor-H.DAT skirt-ACC wear-CAUS-H-PST-D
 ‘The director made the actor wear a skirt.’ (causative)

I argue that H.NOM and H.DAT are assigned in a parallel fashion. Voice is an argument introducer just like Appl (see Wood & Marantz 2017). Similar to how Appl licenses 1/2P to the IO, Voice licenses 1/2P to the subject. It is worth mentioning that a DO cannot receive an H case marker while an IO and a subject can. With this, (3) can be updated as (13). (13) can be reinterpreted as (14) based on (9).

- (13) Subj_H/IO_H ... DO_{*H} (H > non-H)

- (14) Subj_{1[1/2P, R₁]}/IO_{2[1/2P, R₂]} ... DO_{3[∅, R₃]}

An IA realized as the subject can receive an H case marker. This is illustrated in (15), which exhibits unaccusative and passive predicates. Under the proposal advanced in this work, the IA realized as the subject is eligible for 1/2P agreement.

- (15) a. Sensayng.nim-**kkeyse** nemeci-si-ess-e.
 teacher.H-H.NOM fall-H-PST-D
 ‘The teacher fell.’ (unaccusative)
 b. Sensayng.nim-**kkeyse** kyengchal-eyuyhay cap-hi-si-ess-e.
 teacher.H-H.NOM police-by catch-PASS-H-PST-D
 ‘The teacher was caught by the police.’ (passive)

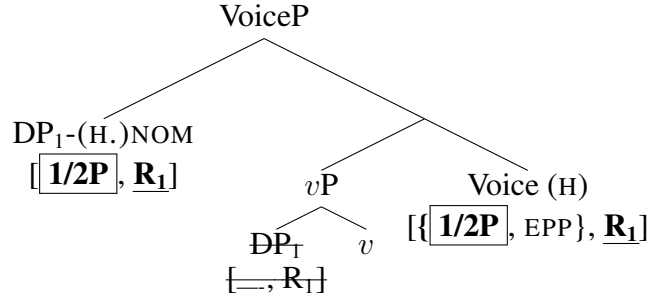
To make sure that our story is complete, I show that the subject of an unergative predicate is also eligible for an H case marker:

- (16) Sensayng.nim-**kkeyse** wus-usi-ess-e.
 teacher.H-H.NOM laugh-H-PST-D
 ‘The teacher laughed.’ (unergative)

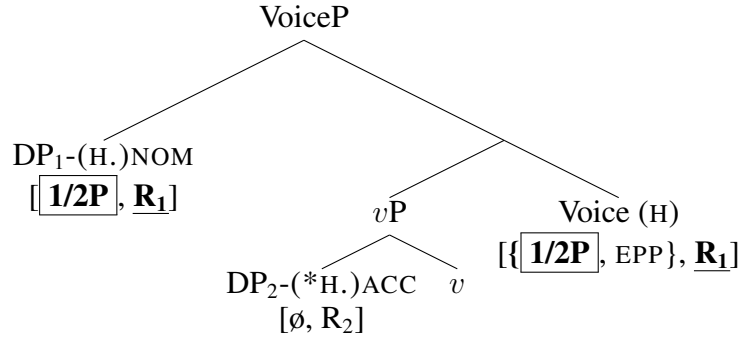
When it comes to the PCC, some have argued that 1/2P is localized on Voice (see Béjar & Rezac 2003, Anagnostopoulou 2005, Nevins 2007, and Stegovec 2020). In fact, this goes hand in hand with my analysis. In cases where Voice does not introduce an external argument (EA), as in unaccusatives and passives, 1/2P is licensed to the IA by Voice once the IA moves to the edge of VoiceP (see Legate 2003 and Lee 2024).

Based on the empirical data from Korean, I have established that 1/2P agreement takes place between (i) Appl and its applied argument and (ii) Voice and the subject. For both cases, I assume that a Spec-head configuration is established where 1/2P on Appl and Voice is licensed to their nominal arguments. (17)–(19) schematizes how H is licensed in unaccusatives, passives, simple transitives, and ditransitives. This paper builds on the insight that agreement may require the bundling of EPP and 1/2P (see Baker 2003, Collins 2004, and Carstens 2005 for related arguments in Bantu languages). I posit that EPP and 1/2P on argument-introducers are checked together by the nominal argument occupying Spec,ApplP and/or Spec,VoiceP. In fact, this is what makes the restrictions on H case markers resemble the PCC. Voice probes R_1 and Appl probes R_2 when the two heads participate in agreement.

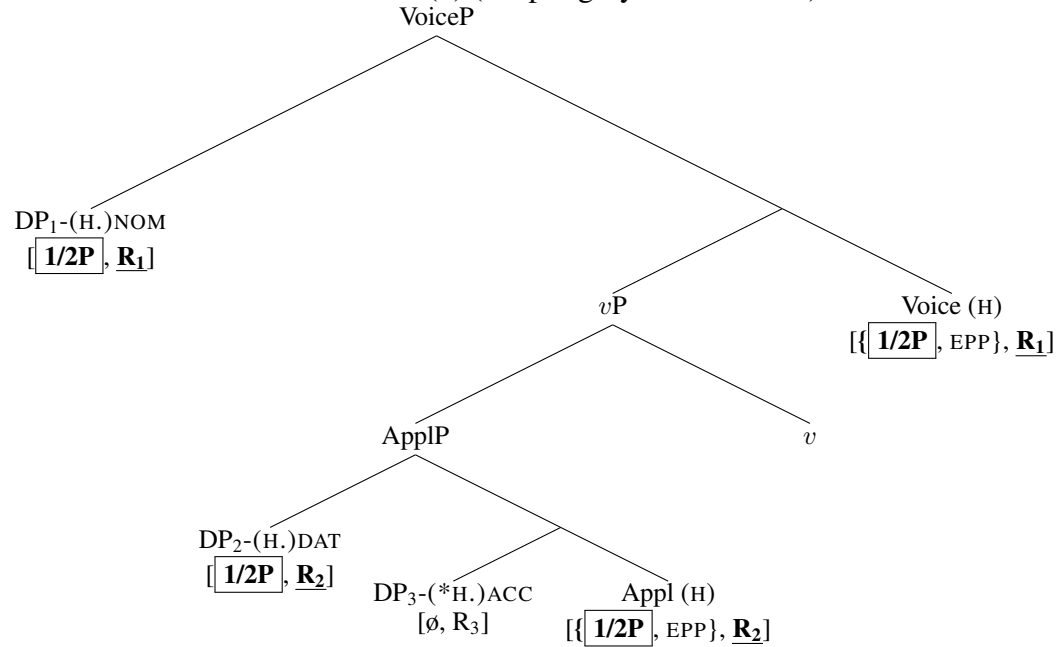
- (17) A derivation for unaccusatives and passives $\Rightarrow$ (15) (adopting Legate 2003)



- (18) A derivation for simple transitives $\Rightarrow$ (11)

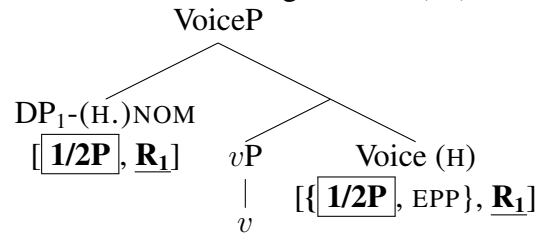


(19) A derivation for ditransitives (4) (adopting Pylkkänen 2008)

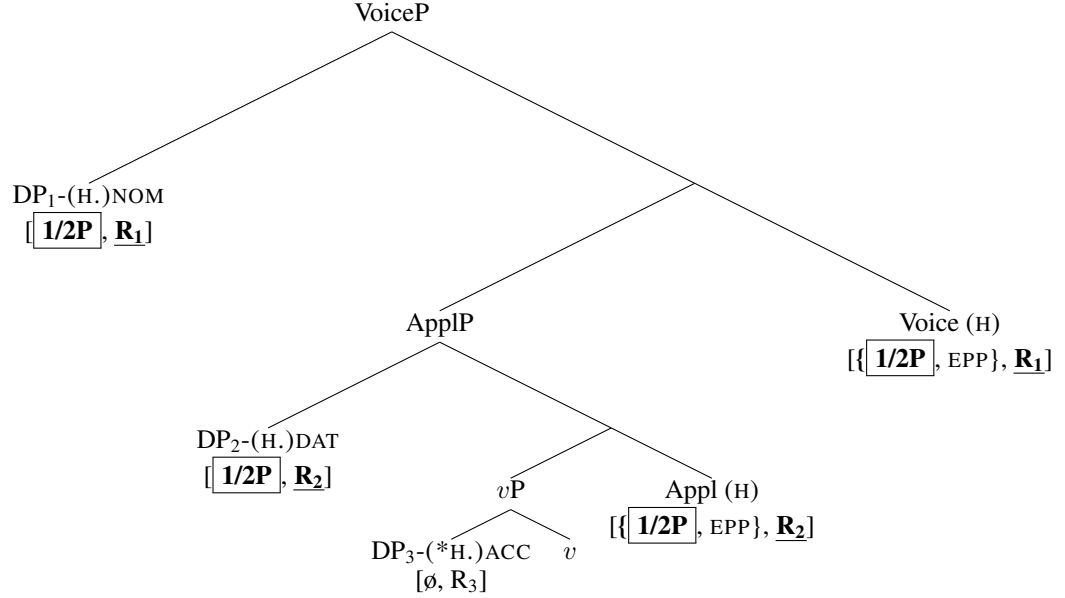


Recall that my analysis extends to unergatives, benefactives, and causatives. (20) and (21) flesh out the relevant details.

(20) A derivation for unergatives (16)



- (21) A derivation for benefactives and causatives (12)



Before concluding this section, I highlight that my analysis has implications about Korean argument structure. Prior to movement, the IO c-commands the DO but not vice versa. Jung & Miyagawa (2004) and Lee (2024) arrives at the same conclusion. Lee (2024), in particular, argues that a DO must be externally merged in the complement position of the verb (i.e., a first merge situation) whereas applied and external arguments are externally merged in the specifier position of Appl or Voice (i.e., a non-first merge situation). The PCC-inspired analysis put forward in this work is in harmony with Lee’s proposal. Both approaches apply the same idea which is that the IO asymmetrically c-commands the DO. With this in mind, I am in a position to address whether the approach advanced for Korean applies cross-linguistically.

4 Cross-linguistic evidence

While Japanese does not showcase H case markers as Korean does, it exhibits H markers on the predicate. Boeckx & Niinuma (2004) report that object H agreement in Japanese is sensitive to an intervention effect that resembles the PCC effect. That is, object H agreement is associated with the IO instead of the DO in ditransitives. The relevant data is provided in (22) and (23).

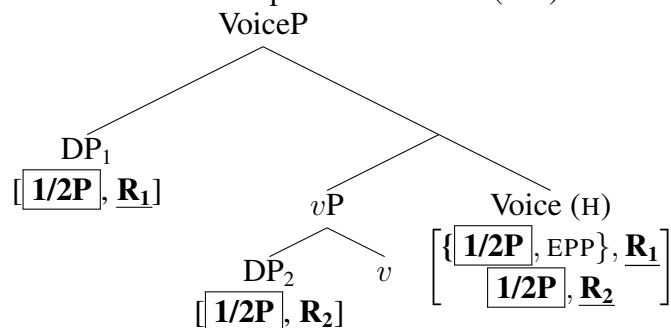
- (22) Hanako-ga Tanaka sensei-ni Mary-o go-syookai-si-ta.
Hanako-NOM Prof.Tanaka-DAT Mary-ACC H-introduce-do-PST
‘Hanako introduced Mary to Prof. Tanaka.’
- (23) *Hanako-ga Mary-ni Tanaka sensei-o go-syookai-si-ta.
Hanako-NOM Mary-DAT Prof.Tanaka-ACC H-introduce-do-PST
‘Hanako introduced Prof. Tanaka to Mary.’ (Boeckx & Niinuma 2004:456)

(24a) shows that object H agreement can target the DO in simple transitives. No intervention effect is observed here due to the absence of an IO. Japanese honorification can be suppressed, however, if the subject referent holds a higher social status than the DO referent. This is demonstrated in (24b). From this, I know that the subject referent has to be taken into consideration when object honorification is at play.

- (24) a. Taroo-wa butyoo-o go-syootai-si-ta.
 Taroo-TOP manager-ACC H-invite-do-PST
 ‘Taroo invited the manager.’
 b. #Syatyoo-wa butyoo-o go-syootai-si-ta.
 CEO-TOP manager-ACC H-invite-do-PST
 ‘#The CEO invited the manager.’ (Ikawa 2022:528)

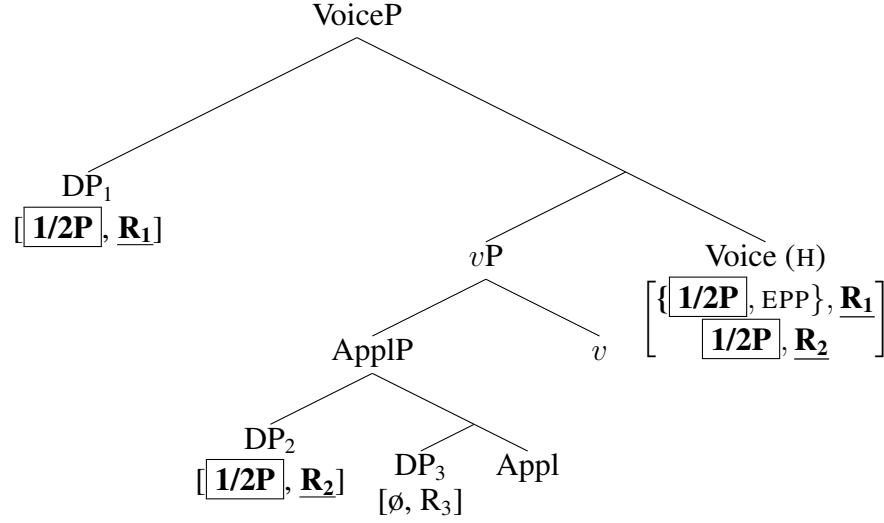
Ikawa (2022) argues that a probe searches downwards for the closest c-commanding argument (e.g., an IA) and another probe on the same head searches upwards for the closest non-commanding argument (e.g., an EA). Based on the discussion in Section 3, the speaker (1P) and the addressee (2P) also need to be factored in when honorificity is determined. Recall that Voice hosts 1/2P (see also Boeckx & Ninuma 2004). When multiple instances of agreement take place, the referents, R_1 and R_2 , are probed by Voice. (25) and (26) schematize the derivations for simple transitives and ditransitives in Japanese.²

- (25) A derivation for simple transitives $\Rightarrow$ (24a)



²In Japanese, it is not entirely clear whether Appl participates in 1/2P agreement. Perhaps language parameter is at play here. Future work remains to be done on this topic.

(26) A derivation for ditransitives (22)



Overall, the realization of H is made possible via φ -feature agreement. Specifically, I claim that agreement is not about H per se, but about person features that have been widely adopted to characterize syntactic agreement patterns and the PCC. Crucially, honorification boils down to person feature agreement displaying a version of the PCC. Hence, two independent-looking phenomena receive a parallel treatment.

5 Conclusion

I have argued that the realization of H is made possible via φ -feature agreement. Specifically, I have claimed that agreement is not about H per se, but about person features that have already been widely adopted to account for other aspects of the grammar. We have gained independent evidence for placing 1/2P on an argument introducer such as Voice and Appl based on the previous literature addressing the PCC. This brings us to the following question: Why are argument introducers recruited for the realization of H? Note that a similar kind of inquiry can be leveled at the following question: Why should the PCC hold in the first place? While there are unanswered aspects to this question, I believe the PCC and the restrictions on honorification can be treated on par with each other. Hopefully, this brings us closer to a unified approach that provides a fuller explanation as to why these restrictions hold in syntax.

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